

ETHICAL DISCLAIMER

Time Tokens & Time Tower · DECO3500 Team 3 · Prepared by Yucheng Chen · Version 1, Week 9, Semester 2 2026

Tool: Ethics for Designers — Ethical Disclaimer (Gispen). This is a living document: it will be updated after each evaluation round.

1. THE CURRENT SITUATION IS...	2. THE STAKEHOLDERS ARE...	3. OUR DESIGN INTENTIONS ARE...
<i>What do you want to change in the current situation? Why?</i> Our interviews suggest that gaming itself is rarely described as the problem. The problem is that a game can take priority over a real-life commitment at the wrong moment. Existing tools respond by restricting play — screen-time limits and app blockers — which treats the player as the problem and removes their autonomy. In a share house, each resident's time use is invisible to the others, even though they share a daily rhythm and a common space. What we want to change: make real-life priorities visible at the moment gaming competes for attention, so people can make that comparison themselves — without being restricted.	Direct - Residents who use the Time Tokens - Co-residents who can see the shared Time Tower Indirect - Residents who decline to participate — still visible by their absence - Partners and guests present in the shared space - Head-tenant or landlord who may introduce the device - Future tenants who inherit the device and its data - Research and evaluation participants	Users: young adults living in share houses who play video games. Context: the common area of a shared home (kitchen, living room), where every resident has their own set of tokens and the Tower is visible to all. Purpose: help residents notice how their day is being allocated, and compare the pull of a game against a real-life commitment before they start. How: a tangible gesture — flip a cube to start a timed block (Work/Study, Entertainment, Rest), dock it into the shared Tower to deposit it. Mechanism: ambient peer awareness as light, mutual accountability — not restriction, ranking or rewards.

4. UNETHICAL SITUATIONS WITH OUR DESIGN...			
Dark, wrong or weird <i>What would be really wrong?</i>	1 One housemate's Tower is mostly "Entertainment", and it becomes a running joke in the house.	2 Rest is read as laziness — "5 hours of rest" becomes a publicly visible failure.	3 A resident with a chronic illness or depression is silently measured against everyone else's "normal" day.
Longer-term use <i>What happens over a longer period of time?</i>	4 Time becomes a currency: rest has to be "earned" before it feels allowed.	5 The Tower becomes a real-life daily quest — people log for the Tower, not for themselves.	6 Someone struggling with problematic gaming sees their "wasted" time made physical and visible, deepening self-blame.
Wrong people / shared <i>What if it is used by the "wrong" people, or shared?</i>	7 A head-tenant or landlord installs it and expects sub-tenants to take part.	8 One resident declines — and their empty Tower becomes the thing everyone notices.	9 The daily record is brought up in an argument about chores or rent.
Different context / purpose <i>Different context, purpose, or combined with other technology?</i>	10 An employer or school adopts it as productivity monitoring.	11 A controlling partner or parent uses it to watch someone's day.	12 Linked to a smart plug or console so games lock when "Work" falls below a target.
Access / hacking <i>Who can access it? What if people hack it?</i>	13 Someone flips another person's cube to fake or sabotage their record.	14 Guests read the Tower and learn residents' routines — e.g. when the house is usually empty.	15 Data stays on the device after a resident moves out.

5. WE TAKE RESPONSIBILITY FOR...

Which situations fall within the ethical scope of the project? Why?

Shame produced by comparison (1, 9)

Design response: no leaderboard, scores or streaks; Towers sit side by side, never ranked; no notifications to others; daily reset.

Why ours: comparison mechanics are features we choose to include or leave out.

The moral coding of time (2, 3)

Design response: Rest is shown in a positive, warm colour, never as loss; users can relabel categories.

Why ours: the category system and its visual language are our design decisions.

Time-as-currency and "daily quest" dynamics (4, 5)

Design response: no balance, debt or spending vocabulary; the Tower fills and never drains; no default goal, and any goal is private.

Why ours: the metaphor came from our own concept (In Time).

Harm to vulnerable users (6)

Design response: positioned as awareness, not intervention — never blocks, penalises or reports; no alarm colours; evaluation screens out people currently seeking help.

Why ours: this is foreseeable from the domain we chose to research.

Absence being read as guilt (8)

Design response: unlogged time is shown as empty, not as a category; a private mode lets any block stay off the Tower.

Why ours: what the display shows — and implies — is ours.

Data persistence and access (13–15)

Design response: shared layer shows aggregate colour only; local storage, no cloud; data clears daily; physical reset for move-out.

Why ours: the storage and sharing architecture is ours to set.

Our research participants

Design response: informed consent, anonymised as P1...Pn, recordings stored locally and deleted after the course, free to stop at any time.

Why ours: we run the studies.

5. WE DO NOT TAKE RESPONSIBILITY FOR...

Which situations are outside the ethical scope of the project? Why? Which might be someone else's responsibility?

Existing power relations in share houses (7)

Whose responsibility: residents, landlords, and tenancy law.

Why outside scope: we cannot fix unequal tenancy relationships. We avoid amplifying them — there is no admin view and visibility is symmetric.

Pressure housemates put on each other outside the device (9)

Whose responsibility: the residents themselves.

Why outside scope: we can avoid manufacturing extra pressure through ranking or alerts, but not govern how people treat each other.

Deliberate repurposing for workplace, school or partner surveillance (10, 11)

Whose responsibility: the person or institution that adopts it.

Why outside scope: this is outside our intended use. We make it harder by offering no export, remote access or account system.

Third-party hardware that turns it into a restriction tool (12)

Whose responsibility: whoever builds the integration.

Why outside scope: we provide no API, and our intention is explicitly non-restrictive.

Clinical support for problematic gaming (6)

Whose responsibility: clinicians and support services.

Why outside scope: the device is not a treatment. We signpost support rather than implying it is a remedy.

Deliberate faking of one's own or others' records (13)

Whose responsibility: the users.

Why outside scope: the data is self-reported, and we state openly that it is not an accurate record.

Game design that drives over-play

Whose responsibility: game developers and platforms.

Why outside scope: we respond to the effects of engagement design; we do not control it.